

the forums allow different categories of discussion, and also enable tagging them.

Vanilla features

Vanilla is available as downloadable software and also as a service. If you prefer Vanilla as a service, you need to choose a monthly subscription fee based on the size of the organisation. Though we focus on the downloadable version, you can grasp Vanilla's features and flexibility on the subscription option.

Easy to get started: The most important feature of any discussion forum is to allow new users to get started without much learning. While other software could have more features, Vanilla beats them because of its easy-to-use interface.

Popularity-based sorting: The discussions are sorted based on popularity and likes. This makes it easy for users to find hot topics.

Highly portable: Vanilla is implemented in PHP, making it highly portable on various platforms.

Customisable: This software was created to be customisable—regarding not just its look-and-feel, but its functionality too. The architectural premise was to keep the core light and fast, and allow extension in the form of plugins and applications.

Easy integration: This software has the option to integrate with social networking sites such as Facebook and Twitter.

Mobile client support: Vanilla comes with a mobile theme suited for smaller screens, which is a delight for users on mobile devices.

Setting up Vanilla

You need to have the LAMP stack pre-installed; minimum versions include PHP 5.2.0 and MySQL 5. Download the software from <http://vanillaforums.org/>. Unzip the zip file into the Web server's *htdocs* directory. Create a database named *vanilla* via the MySQL prompt or *phpMyAdmin* GUI. Visit <http://localhost/vanilla> in the browser, assuming the directory name under *htdocs* is *vanilla*. Fill the form with the username (admin role), the password and enter the database name as *vanilla*. Submitting the form will take you to the Vanilla administration page.

Customisation

Homepage layout: Vanilla has options to select the homepage of every user, to suit their interaction mode. The choice is between *discussions view*, *categories view* and *activity view*. *Discussions view* shows all discussions in reverse chronological order, in any category. The *categories view* groups discussions based on category, and only shows the discussion and comments count. The *activity view* shows new posts and new users added to the forum.



Figure 1: Discussion forum



Figure 2: Getting started



Figure 3: Customised logo in banner

Banner customisation: The forum banner can be customised to suit the kind of forum being hosted—including changing the title and logo. Figure 3 shows a changed logo.

Look and feel selections: Vanilla has options to change themes and layouts based on user devices. The default theme is for desktops, but there are also embed-friendly and mobile viewing versions.

Messages to the community: As administrator, you can set information-based (e.g., new categories created) and warning messages (reminders of forum rules and company policies) on any of the pages on the forum. You can choose not only the messages, but also which page to display them on, where to display them, and whether or not the user can close the message. You can also enable or disable the appearance of a message.

User addition: User addition can be done by the administrator or through the self-registration option, which is best for a community that's growing large. Administrators,